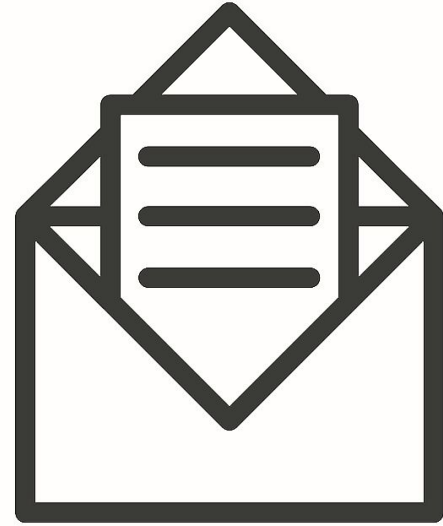


Lesson 8: Fact checking

HS192 Introduction to Writing - 2
@ IITGN, 2025-26



Today's learning objective

Evaluate news report using SIFT method

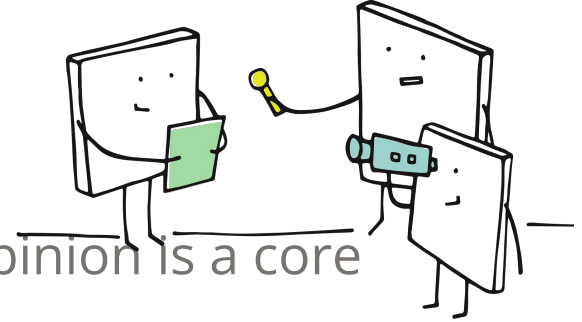
Media and me

We are connected to the world through various mediators tirelessly behind the scene.

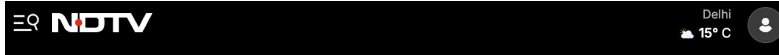
Whether the media is public or private, owned by many stakeholders or a few individual, the generated information is typically categorized into:

- News (reporting straight facts)
- Opinions (delivering writer's opinion)

Recognising the difference between news and opinion is a core news literacy skill.



Checking fact vs. opinion reporting from headline



Delhi Records Second-Best Air Quality Month Since 2022

The CREA's analysis showed that January 2025, with an average AQI of 306, was the best January when it came to air pollution since 2022, when the monthly average AQI stood at 279.

Press Trust of India | [Delhi News](#) | Jan 31, 2026 07:48 am IST ⓘ

Read Time: 2 mins



This seems to be based on facts and value judgement may not be needed



Opinion | The India-EU Deal Isn't Really About Tariffs



Aditya Sinha

Opinion, Updated: Jan 28, 2026 11:30 am IST ⓘ



You want to understand what evidence and analysis can be made to support the claim.

"Aha! In the case of fact-reporting"

Why not?

"the description as is!"

Misinformation

Satire or parody

No intention to cause harm but has potential to fool

Misleading content

Misleading use of information to frame an issue or individual

Imposter content

When genuine sources are impersonated

Fabricated content

New content is 100% false, designed to deceive and do harm

False connection

When headlines, visuals, or captions don't support the content

False context

When genuine content is shared with false contextual information

Manipulated content

When genuine information or imagery is manipulated to deceive



Yes, There's an Asteroid Coming for Earth Right Before Election Day

POPULAR MECHANICS Jennifer Leman, Popular Mechanics • August 24, 2020



NEWS

The Race Is Over: This Man Who Pointed A Leaf Blower Downward At Full Blast Has Beaten NASA And SpaceX To Mars

JULY 17, 2020



redit: SCIEPRO - Getty Images

Breaking: Trump sending Border Patrol agents to forcibly separate immigrant children from their families!!



Satire or parody

Not all fake news is meant to be deceptive. Some of it is simply meant to be funny or satirical.

This story was taken from The Onion, a well-known satirical news website

If you're not sure whether a website is meant to be satirical rather than real news, check Wikipedia's List of Satirical News Websites.



Facebook Apologizes For Giving Mark Zuckerberg A Platform

MENLO PARK, CA—In response to criticism about the social network's failure to address the spread of falsehoods and offensive content on its site, Facebook apologized Thursday for giving Mark Zuckerberg a platform. "Lies and harassment have absolutely no place on Facebook, and we want to express our deep regret at offering someone like Mark Zuckerberg a space to..."

Sugar as addictive as cocaine, heroin, studies suggest

False connection

By ROSEMARY BLACK | DAILY NEWS STAFF WRITER | DEC 11, 2008 | 7:13 PM

It's one addiction that won't land you in court or an inpatient rehab. But sugar - as anyone who

Sometimes legitimate newspapers, magazines, and television shows publish news that is real, but the way they present the news is misleading.

Here the New York Daily News, a paper that has been in publication since 1919, published a story in which the headline claims that sugar is as addictive as cocaine and heroin. These sensational headlines, referred to as "Clickbait", don't always give you the whole story.

If you were to read more of the article, you would discover that this theory has only been proven to exist in rats, not humans.

Misleading content

Misleading content is the by far the most difficult kind of fake news to uncover. Misleading content can find its way into many, many real news stories and the reason it's so hard to discover is because it requires some kind of expertise or knowledge about a given subject to determine whether the facts and details in any news article are being misrepresented.

On 3 June 2018, multiple web sites falsely reported that it is now “against the law” for Californians to shower and do laundry on the same day, thanks to supposedly draconian water conservation legislation signed into law by Governor Jerry Brown.

For example, the conspiratorial web site [ZeroHedge](#) reported that:

Governor Jerry Brown is retiring but not before he passes a few draconian laws as parting gifts for California. Two bills were signed into law on Thursday of last week to “help California be better prepared for future droughts and the effects of climate change.”

The mandatory water conservation standards will be permanent, according to their wording, and not just for use in times of crisis. To make a long story short, now that these bills are law, it's illegal to take a shower and do a load of laundry in the same day because you'll exceed your “ration.”

The bills in question, Senate Bill [606](#) and Assembly Bill [1668](#), were indeed signed into law by Governor Brown on 31 May 2018 (and Brown has indeed reached his term limit as governor). Neither bill, however, carries language penalizing consumers for taking a shower and doing laundry on the same day. Instead, they outline conservation mandates for water districts and municipalities, and water agencies can be fined if they fail to meet conservation goals (but not until 2027).

False context

This image has been circulating attached to misleading stories of nefarious activities and voter fraud claiming that Detroit ballot counters were covering windows

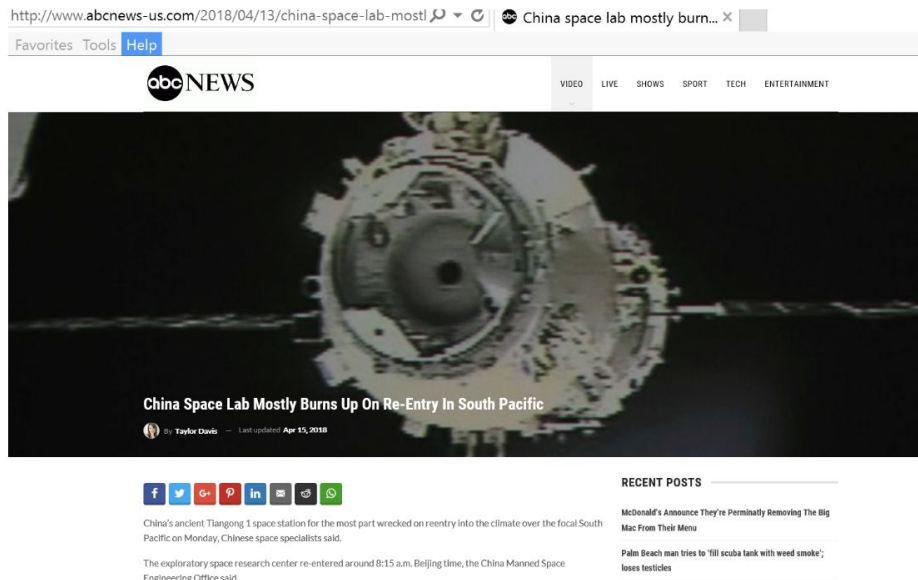
to hide illegal activities. But Lawrence Garcia, an attorney for the City of Detroit, said that the windows were partially blocked because of concern voter information could be wrongfully revealed to the public. Those concerns were compounded by the fact that protesters standing outside the ballot-counting area were taking photographs and recording video. This is a valid photo from election day in Detroit, however, it is being placed in a completely false context.



Imposter content

Some fake news websites try to pretend that they are other news agencies. The snapshot from the above website is pretending to be ABC News, but it is not.

How can you spot these imposter websites? It can be difficult sometimes, but you can almost always sniff-out them out by checking the URL. The above URL is not from abcnews.com, it is from abcnews-us.com. Imposter news will never be able to publish content from the real news agency's website. So if you're unsure whether a source is representing itself truthfully, Google the news source, find its website, and see if the domain in the URL matches. If it doesn't, you have an imposter.



Fabricated content

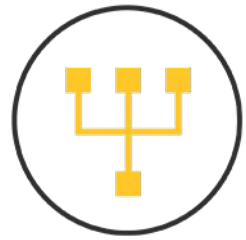


Twitter users discovered that National Human Trafficking Hotline was run by Hillary Clinton

Daughter of the former secretary of state Hillary Clinton has seemingly admitted that the 'Pizzagate' - the conspiracy theory born out of the Wikileaks emails allegedly exposing politicians running pedophile rings - is real on her Twitter on Thursday.

Some stories are simply made-up and have no basis in reality. Good lateral reading practices will quickly tell you whether a story is real or fake. Pro-tip: if no one else is reporting a story, it's probably fake.

SIFT



It is a simple 4-step method to help you evaluate information that you find on the web.

This method was developed by Mike Caulfield, Washington State University digital literacy expert.

This fact-checking strategy helps you to quickly make a decision about whether or not a source is worthy of your attention.

SIFT: Stop!

When you find a source - STOP!

Do you know and trust the author, publisher, publication or website?

Stopping before reading allows you to assess the source before you read too much and fall prey to confirmation bias

If you do not, move onto 'I' — Investigate the source



SIFT: Investigate the source

Get off the web page to see what others have said about the source

Open some new tabs in your browser and do a Google and Wikipedia search to see what you can find about the source

Watch the short video below for a demonstration of this strategy

If the source is low quality, unreliable or cannot be verified, move to 'F'
- Find Better Coverage



SIFT: Find better coverage

Look for another source that includes trusted reporting on analysis on the same claim

You can think of this as 'trading up' for a higher quality source

Over time, you will build your own knowledge base of trusted sources

If you aren't able to find an alternative source but would still like to cover the point of view, move on to 'T' - Trace Claims, Quotes, and Media to the Original Context



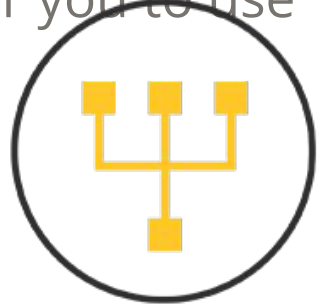
SIFT: Trace claims, quotes and media to the original context

If your original source makes claims or quotes, trace them back to where they came from

To trace claims, look for references, hyperlinks or phrases such as "according to..." - then follow these up

Does your source accurately present the original context?

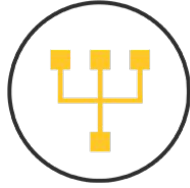
Often, the original reporting or quote is a better option for you to use



Group activity



- Find this article's headline
 - What's your first impression?
- Start the steps of S-I-F-T with Stop!
 - Investigate the coverage
 - Find better coverage
 - Trace claims, quotes, and media to the original content
- How far could you apply S-I-F-T?
 - Record your group's investigation
 - How did your investigation go?
 - What sources did you find as better coverage?
 - **What is your final verdict about the linked article?**



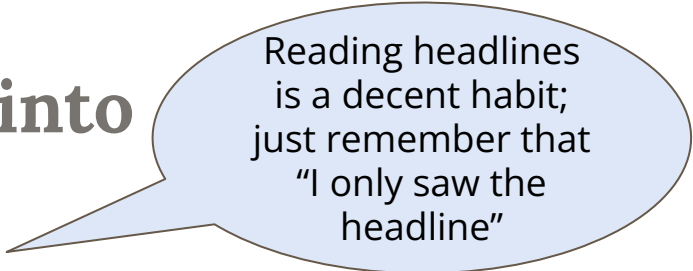
Debrief

While following S-I-F-T, what resources or source pools have your group used?

Share sources that look more reliable or more credible.

Have you read the linked article content? Why or why not?

Common pitfalls we tend to fall into



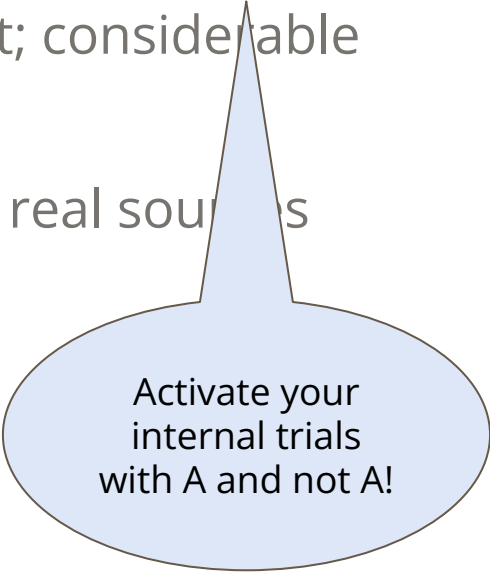
Reading headlines
is a decent habit;
just remember that
"I only saw the
headline"

Reading only headline $\Rightarrow$ accepting as a fact

Confirmation bias (*"It matches what I believe, thus it must be true"*)

.com vs **.edu/.gov** trust myth (many .com are excellent; considerable information on .edu can be outdated)

AI-generated content including hallucinations, without real sources



Activate your
internal trials
with A and not A!

Fact checking is an essential skill for 21st Century

As a generator of knowledge and information, each one of us want to be ethical and accurate about what we hear and understand.

Ethos + Accuracy is required for meaningful information communication

Using the SIFT method can increase your information processing speed and reliability

Practice will make the fact-checking faster (aim for <2 minutes per news in question)

A weekly homework

This week's reflection (Google form) will ask you about a recent news article that you apply the SIFT method. Find an interesting case you would like to report!

Make a pair with a group member, and try it as a pair work now.

Pair activity

- Find a news media or website
 - Pressreader
 - MSN news, Google News, ...
 - Hindustan Times, The Indian Express, ...
- Skim through news reports, does any capture your attention?
 - Identify a news-reporting article that
 - Delivers news that you have not encountered
 - Looks interesting to both of you
- Apply S-I-F-T
 - Record your pair's investigation
 - What is your final verdict about the linked article?